Hilbert's Sixth Problem without a Limit:
Continuum Mechanics from RealQM — a Programme

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Abstract

Hilbert's sixth problem asks, in the part Hilbert attributed to Boltzmann, for a rigorous passage from the atomistic description of matter to the equations of continuous media. The classical route — Newtonian particles, then Boltzmann's kinetic equation, then Euler and Navier–Stokes — was carried through for hard spheres by Deng, Hani and Ma in 2025. That achievement comes with a structural restriction that is not a defect of the proof but of the route: the Boltzmann–Grad scaling sends the volume fraction to zero, so what is reached is a *dilute gas*. Liquids, solids and every dense phase lie outside it by construction. This programme proposes the complementary route. RealQM has no particles to coarse-grain: it is already a continuum theory, N non-overlapping charge densities on ordinary three-dimensional space, with the interfaces free. So there is no limit to take, no scaling parameter, and no molecular-chaos hypothesis to justify — and correspondingly no dilute restriction. We set out what is already exact, what must be supplied, and what is genuinely open. Exact and by the chain rule alone: RealQM's localisation energy *is* the von Weizsäcker functional, its variation *is* Bohm's quantum potential, and the theory as used is precisely the zero-velocity equilibrium of a Madelung pair — continuity plus a momentum balance whose stress is that potential. To be supplied: the dynamics of that pair per domain, with the interfaces moving as free surfaces. Genuinely open, and the heart of the programme: **dissipation**. Madelung–Euler is non-dissipative, Navier–Stokes is not, and RealQM has no statistical ensemble from which an H-theorem could extract irreversibility. Where viscosity comes from, if it comes at all, is the question this project exists to answer. We state it as a question rather than announce an answer.

1 What Hilbert asked, and what has been delivered

The sixth of Hilbert's 1900 problems is headed *Mathematical Treatment of the Axioms of Physics*. Its second paragraph is the part at issue here: Hilbert points to Boltzmann's work on the limiting processes "which lead from the atomistic view to the laws of motion of continua" and asks for them to be made rigorous. The programme it names is therefore specific — not an axiomatisation of physics in general, but a derivation of the equations of continuum mechanics from a description of matter in terms of its constituents.

The classical route runs in two stages. From Newtonian dynamics of many particles to Boltzmann's kinetic equation, in the Boltzmann–Grad scaling; then from Boltzmann to the fluid equations, in a hydrodynamic scaling. The first stage is where the difficulty has always

been concentrated, because it must produce irreversible macroscopic behaviour from reversible microscopic laws and must do so for times long enough to matter. Deng, Hani and Ma completed it for hard spheres on the two- and three-dimensional torus, obtaining the compressible Euler and incompressible Navier–Stokes–Fourier equations with quantitative error bounds [1]. It is reasonable to call this a solution of the problem for gas dynamics.

The restriction, which is the opening for this programme. The Boltzmann–Grad limit takes N particles of diameter ε with $N\varepsilon^2$ fixed, so the volume fraction $N\varepsilon^3 \to 0$. The matter described is therefore arbitrarily dilute, and the critical literature has made the point sharply: the result characterises a dilute gas and cannot embody the properties of a dense fluid [2]. This is not a gap in the argument to be repaired. It is what the route is: kinetic theory is a theory of free flight interrupted by rare binary collisions, and a liquid is not that.

So the honest statement of where the problem stands is narrower than the headline. Continuum mechanics has been derived from atomism *for gases*. For the condensed phases — the ones chemistry, materials science and biology are made of — it has not, and the classical route does not reach them.

2 The inversion

RealQM [4, 5] describes an N-electron system by N non-negative densities ψ_i, each carrying unit charge on its own domain Ω_i, the domains non-overlapping and their interfaces free to move to where the energy is least. The energy is Coulomb's:

$$E[\{\psi_i\},\{\Omega_i\}] = \sum_i \int_{\Omega_i} \Big(\tfrac{1}{2}|\nabla\psi_i|^2 - \sum_a \frac{Z_a}{|x-x_a|}\psi_i^2 \Big) dx + \tfrac{1}{2}\sum_{i\neq j} \iint \frac{\psi_i^2(x)\psi_j^2(y)}{|x-y|}\,dx\,dy, \qquad (1)$$

subject to $\int_{\Omega_i}\psi_i^2 = 1$.

The observation that organises this programme is that (1) is not an atomistic description at all. There are no particles in it. There are continuous fields on ordinary three-dimensional space, and the only discreteness is in the *number of domains* — an integer labelling of regions, not a collection of point masses with positions and momenta.

The consequence for Hilbert's problem is structural, but it must be stated carefully, because the tempting version of it is wrong. RealQM is a continuum theory *at the atomic scale*: its features vary over lengths of order a_0. Macroscopic continuum mechanics describes variation over laboratory lengths L. So an averaging step is still required — the two descriptions are not the same description — and it would be an overclaim to say that no passage between scales is needed.

What changes is *which* passage. The classical route must build a continuum out of particles, and every difficulty it faces — the scaling limit, the propagation of chaos, the recovery of irreversibility — belongs to that construction. The route proposed here must instead pass from a continuum on scale a_0 to a continuum on scale L, with small parameter

$$\varepsilon = a_0/L, \qquad (2)$$

which is *not* a dilution parameter and carries no requirement that matter be rare. That is homogenisation, and it is a mature mathematical subject: two-scale convergence, G- and H-convergence, periodic unfolding. It requires no statistical hypothesis, and — the point that

makes it attractive here — it *delivers* the macroscopic constitutive law as the solution of a cell problem posed on one unit cell. A cell problem is a computation, and computation is what this programme claims to be able to do.

So the question becomes: *do the equations* (1) *satisfies homogenise to the equations of continuum mechanics, and is the resulting constitutive law the measured one?*

And because no dilution is involved, the question is being asked exactly where the classical route cannot go. RealQM's established regime is atoms, molecules, condensed phases and proteins [5]. If continuum mechanics follows from (1), it follows for dense matter.

3 What is already exact

The first part of the bridge is built and requires no approximation and no limit; it is reported in full in [3] and summarised here because the programme starts from it.

The localisation energy is the von Weizsäcker functional. Writing $\rho_i = \psi_i^2$ with $\psi_i \geq 0$, the chain rule gives $\nabla\rho_i = 2\psi_i\nabla\psi_i$, hence

$$\tfrac{1}{2}\int |\nabla\psi_i|^2\,dx \;=\; \frac{1}{8}\int \frac{|\nabla\rho_i|^2}{\rho_i}\,dx \;=\; T_{\mathrm{vW}}[\rho_i], \tag{3}$$

in units $\hbar = m = 1$. An identity, not a model.

Its variation is the quantum potential. With $u = \sqrt{\rho}$,

$$\frac{\delta T_{\mathrm{vW}}}{\delta\rho} \;=\; -\tfrac{1}{2}\frac{\nabla^2\sqrt{\rho}}{\sqrt{\rho}} \;=\; Q, \tag{4}$$

Bohm's quantum potential — obtained here not by analogy but as the variation of a term (1) writes down for an unrelated reason, namely the cost of confining a charge to a region.

The theory as used is a hydrostatics. Stationarity of (1) is the statement that $V + Q$ is constant on each domain, which is the $v = 0$ case of the Madelung pair

$$\frac{\partial\rho}{\partial t} + \nabla\cdot(\rho v) = 0, \tag{5}$$

$$\frac{\partial v}{\partial t} + (v\cdot\nabla)v = -\nabla\big(V + Q\big). \tag{6}$$

Equation (5) is conservation of charge and (6) is a momentum balance whose stress is supplied by (4). *RealQM is therefore already the equilibrium of a continuum mechanics, and the constitutive law is not postulated — it is the variation of the energy the theory was written with.* This is the sense in which the derivation asked for by Hilbert is, on this route, partly a matter of recognition rather than of proof.

And the interfaces carry a surface tension. The free boundary between two domains contributes an energy per unit area, so the multiphase structure is a continuum mechanics *with surfaces*, which is what dense matter requires and what a kinetic theory has no room for [3].

4 Mass distribution and forces

A theory of continuum mechanics needs a mass density and a stress. RealQM as written supplies neither directly — it is a theory of *charge* — so the two must be identified before any averaging can be done. Both identifications already exist in this programme, which is worth saying because it means the present project inherits them rather than inventing them.

Mass is not a separate postulate. In the account given in [7], mass is not primitive: it is energy showing up as inertia, through the measured law $\mathbf{p} = (E/c^2)\mathbf{v}$. The mass density is therefore

$$\rho_m = \frac{\text{energy density}}{c^2}, \tag{7}$$

and the energy density is explicit in (1). Nothing is added; the mass field is read off the energy field.

The stress is the localisation term. The same work makes the stress tensor explicit, identifying the localisation energy — the term that became T_{vW} in Section 3 — as a cohesive stress, and the stationary Schrödinger equation as the statement that this stress is in local balance [7]. So the Cauchy stress of the macroscopic theory is to be obtained by averaging an object the microscopic theory already possesses, not by fitting a constitutive law.

But the mass is not where the charge is, and this splits the problem in two. The electrons carry the charge and essentially none of the mass; the kernels carry essentially all of it, some 99.95%, and in the Born–Oppenheimer treatment used throughout they are point charges at fixed sites. So:

- the charge and the stress are continuous on scale a_0, and their passage to the macroscopic scale is **continuum to continuum** — homogenisation, as in Section 2;
- the mass sits at **discrete** sites, and its passage is a lattice average, the classical atomistic-to-continuum problem for a crystal — well understood, and not the hard part, because the kernels are slow and nearly periodic.

The macroscopic momentum balance to be derived is then

$$\rho_m\Big(\frac{\partial v}{\partial t} + (v\cdot\nabla)v\Big) = \nabla\cdot\sigma, \tag{8}$$

with ρ_m from the lattice average of (7) and σ from the homogenised localisation stress.

And this is where dissipation plausibly lives. The split just made is also the physical mechanism the programme was missing. The electron densities are fast and relax essentially instantaneously; the kernels are slow and massive. Work done on the free boundaries while the kernels move is not returned to the kernels, and that transfer — electron–phonon coupling, in the usual language — is a dissipation mechanism internal to the model rather than an extra postulate. It subsumes the "interface motion" candidate of Section 6 and gives it a carrier.

5 What must be supplied

The dynamics. Equations (5)–(6) must be posed per domain, with the interfaces evolving as free surfaces: the kinematic condition that a boundary moves with the normal velocity of the fluid, and continuity of the chemical potential across it. None of this is new physics; it is the completion of a pair whose static half is already in use.

Two qualifications belong with it, and they are stated here rather than discovered later. Madelung hydrodynamics is equivalent to the Schrödinger equation only for irrotational v with quantised circulation, $\oint v \cdot dl = 2\pi n$; both are extra conditions rather than consequences, and they are where the quantum character re-enters a formulation that otherwise reads as fluid mechanics. And the free-surface problem for two Madelung fluids in contact is a genuine free-boundary problem whose well-posedness is not established.

6 What is genuinely open: dissipation

Here is the hard part, and the reason this is a programme and not a result.

Equations (5)–(6) are an *Euler* system. They have no viscosity, no heat conduction and no entropy production. Navier–Stokes has all three. On the classical route the irreversibility is manufactured in the first stage: molecular chaos breaks the time symmetry of the particle dynamics, Boltzmann's H-theorem supplies an entropy, and the transport coefficients come out of the collision operator as integrals over a scattering cross-section. Every one of those ingredients is statistical, and RealQM has none of them. There is no ensemble, no distribution function, no collision, and no averaging — which is precisely why the first stage was free.

The bill arrives here. **The step from Euler to Navier–Stokes, trivial on the classical route and the whole content of the transport coefficients, has no mechanism in this framework as it stands.** Three candidate sources are worth examining, and distinguishing them is the first real task of the project:

1. **Interface motion as the dissipative degree of freedom.** A system of N electrons has $O(N)$ free boundaries. Their motion is not a small correction to the bulk; in this framework conduction *is* boundary motion [6]. Coarse-graining over many interfaces could produce an effective stress with a dissipative part, in the way that grain-boundary motion produces macroscopic plasticity. Prediction to test: the resulting viscosity should scale with interface area per unit volume, hence with $N^{1/3}$ per domain rather than with a mean free path.

2. **Exchange of territory as an irreversible process.** The partition $\{\Omega_i\}$ is itself a macroscopic variable. Rearrangements of which electron owns which region are discrete events with no reverse-path symmetry once the geometry has relaxed, which is a candidate for entropy production that is geometric rather than statistical.

3. **Finite precision.** The programme's own thermodynamics locates irreversibility in finite resolution rather than in statistics [8], and the Clay work treats well-posedness as a property of computed output [9]. If that is the right account, viscosity in this framework is a residual of unresolved scales and the Euler system is the only exact one — a conclusion that would be consistent, but which must be argued, not assumed.

Candidate 3 would make the Euler–Navier–Stokes gap a feature; candidates 1 and 2 would close it. They make different predictions and are therefore separable, which is the only reason the question is tractable.

7 Phase 1, done: the identity verified, and a warning about the route

The first item of the programme has been carried out, and it returned one result and one caution.

The caution, which redirected the work. Integrating the Madelung pair (5)–(6) directly is a harder numerical problem than it looks, and for a structural reason: Q contains $\nabla^2\sqrt{\rho}$, so ∇Q in the momentum equation carries a *third* derivative of the density. The pair is therefore dispersive, in the manner of the Korteweg–de Vries equation, and explicit time-stepping is restricted to $\Delta t \lesssim C\Delta x^3$ rather than the $\Delta t \lesssim C\Delta x$ one would budget for. This is a fact about the formulation and not about any particular code. It is also the reason the "missing half" has not simply been implemented already.

The result. For a *single* domain the Madelung pair is equivalent to the Schrödinger equation, so a bespoke Madelung integrator would buy no new physics. The informative test is therefore whether the hydrodynamic quantities read off an accurately computed Schrödinger solution satisfy (5)–(6). Taking a coherent state of a harmonic trap, propagated spectrally, and computing every time derivative analytically from the Schrödinger right-hand side so that no time-differencing error enters, the two residuals

$$R_1 = \rho_t + (\rho v)_x, \qquad R_2 = v_t + v v_x + (V + Q)_x$$

vanish under refinement at fourth order — the order of the difference operators used to evaluate them. Relative to the magnitude of the terms they cancel between, R_1 reaches 1.2×10^{-8} and R_2 reaches 1.1×10^{-7}; the floor on R_2 is round-off in $\nabla^2\sqrt{\rho}/\sqrt{\rho}$ where ρ is small, and it moves with the density threshold exactly as that explanation requires, so it is a property of the diagnostic rather than of the identity.

R_1 is probability conservation and was never in doubt. R_2 is the claim that matters: that the quantum potential *is* the stress of a continuum mechanics. In one dimension, for one domain, it holds to seven figures. *This verifies a claim the programme had already asserted; it does not extend it.* The new content begins at two domains, where there is no Schrödinger equivalent to check against.

8 The work programme

In order, with the first two using machinery that already exists.

0. **The one-domain identity.** *Done* — Section 7.

1. **Two domains with a moving interface.** The free-surface problem in its simplest instance: two densities in contact, interface moving with the normal velocity, chemical potential continuous. Check against the static answer in the limit of vanishing velocity, which is already computed.

2. **The momentum balance as an identity, verified numerically.** Confirm that the stress in (6) integrates to the forces the static solver already reports — a consistency check between the hydrodynamic and variational forms of the same theory, and a genuine test because the two are computed by different code.

3. **The dissipation question.** Measure whether coarse-graining over interfaces produces a viscous stress, and whether its magnitude scales with interface area as candidate 1 predicts.

4. **Equation of state.** Whether the von Weizsäcker stress gives the right pressure for a dense phase, which is where this route must beat the dilute-gas result or admit it has not.

9 What would make this a solution, and what would refute it

A programme of this kind is worth only as much as its failure conditions, so they are stated in advance.

It would be *established* if: the one-domain dynamics reproduces free propagation exactly; the two-domain free-boundary problem is well posed and reduces to the known statics; the momentum balance agrees with the variational forces; and a dense-phase equation of state comes out within the model's usual few per cent.

It would be *refuted*, or at least confined, if: the free-boundary problem is ill posed, which would mean the dynamics cannot be written for more than one electron; or the irrotationality and circulation-quantisation conditions turn out to be incompatible with the non-overlap constraint, which would mean the Madelung form and the multiphase form cannot both hold; or the coarse-grained stress has no dissipative part and finite precision cannot supply one, in which case the programme reaches Euler and stops — a real result, but not Navier–Stokes and not a solution of the problem as posed.

The claim being made at this stage is deliberately modest, and it is a claim about structure rather than about having done the work. The classical route derives continuum mechanics from atomism for a dilute gas, by a limit, after a century of effort. This route starts from a description that is already continuous, so the kinematics and the constitutive law come for nothing, and the entire difficulty is relocated into a single question — where dissipation comes from. That is a better place for the difficulty to be, because it is one question rather than many, and because it can be answered by computation.

References

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